The Mississippi Black Codes

State of Mississippi · 1865

Source: Mississippi Black Codes (1865). Public domain. Continuous passage.

> Right after the Civil War, Mississippi's legislature passed laws to control freedpeople — forcing labor contracts, allowing forced “apprenticeship” of Black children, and criminalizing unemployment — recreating slavery in all but name and provoking Radical Reconstruction.

All contracts for labor made with freedmen, free negroes and mulattoes for a longer period than one month shall be in writing . . . and if the laborer shall quit the service of the employer before the expiration of his term of service, without good cause, he shall forfeit his wages for that year up to the time of quitting. Every civil officer shall, and every person may, arrest and carry back to his or her legal employer any freedman, free negro, or mulatto who shall have quit the service of his or her employer . . . without good cause.

[. . .]

All freedmen, free negroes and mulattoes . . . over the age of eighteen years, found . . . with no lawful employment or business . . . shall be deemed vagrants, and on conviction thereof shall be fined . . . and imprisonment at the discretion of the court.